unresolved missing women cases in the 2016-22 period (till September). In hilly Pathanamthitta district alone, 12 women are still untraced.

Crimes related to the occult are not new to Kerala. And it's not restricted to the Hindu faith either. The Christian community—which officially bars superstition—is full of such faith healers. The Latin Catholic church had expelled ex-Kochi bishop John Thattungal after he sanctified the bishop's house with the menstrual blood of a young woman back in 2008. There are even prayer groups celebrating 'Black Mass' (satan worship) on social media.

Kerala had plans to introduce an anti-black magic legislation way back in 2008, but the then Left Front government got cold feet after vehement objections by religious leaders. A 2014 draft bill went the same way. The Pinarayi Vijayan government had in 2021 assured the assembly that the 'Kerala Prevention and Eradication of Inhuman Evil Practices, Sorcery and Black Magic' bill was on its way. The CM says it will be tabled soon.

"Historically, Kerala has never been a land conducive to such extreme practices," says historian K.V. Kunhikrishnan. "The current trend of aggressive consumerism and the need to resolve personal problems through black magic point to serious ruptures in the social psyche of Kerala. Unfortunately, the media too is promoting these godmen." There may be some truth to this. A day after the Elanthoor story broke, the state's top two vernacular dailies had at least 10 classified ads offering sundry sorcery 'services'.

Meanwhile, in another bizarre development, Elanthoor has become a tourist hot spot. Hundreds of visitors land up every day to see Bhagaval Singh's house. Special taxi services are plying from nearby towns, and touts offer guided tours of the 'crime scene' and an inside track on "what actually happened". ■

ANI



FAST MOVERS Amit Shah with Yogi Adityanath and other BJP leaders in Sitab Diara village, JP's birthplace in Saran district

BJP IN BIHAR

MISSION BIHAR: THE 'JP' IN BJP

By Amitabh Srivastava

Politics is the art of timely appropriation. And who could be more artful in the craft than the BJP, which has now turned to anti-Emergency icon Jayaprakash Narayan, popularly known as JP?

On October 11, Union home minister Amit Shah reached Bihar for the second time in 18 days. Obviously, the state, which has 40 Lok Sabha seats, is high on the BJP's electoral calculus after chief minister Nitish Kumar dumped it in August to form an alternative government with the RJD, Congress and four other parties. Time and place are key symbolic tools. Guess when and where Shah arrived, with Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath in tow? Day: JP's 120th birth anniversary. Venue: Sitab Diara village, Saran district, JP's birthplace. As Shah unveiled a statue of the socialist icon, he attacked those who claimed to be disciples of JP but are sitting in the Congress's "lap" for power. A plum barb aimed jointly at Nitish and Lalu Prasad.

JP's legacy has special salience in Bihar. The state has been ruled by the followers of India's prominent socialist leader for over three decades now, with deft caste engineering skills. First, it was Lalu. His party, the RJD, had complete grip over the state from 1990 to 2005. Then came Nitish, whose reign—17 years and counting—has already made him Bihar's longest-serving chief minister. Several leaders of the ruling JD(U) and RJD, besides the BJP's Sushil Kumar Modi, cut their political teeth in the battle against the